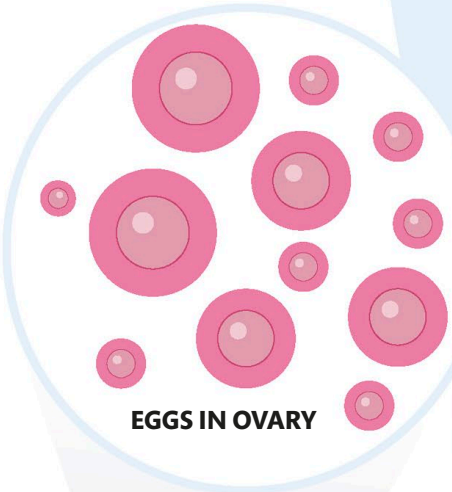
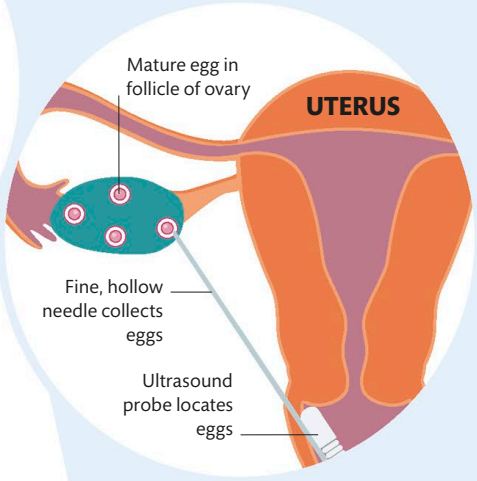
In vitro fertilization

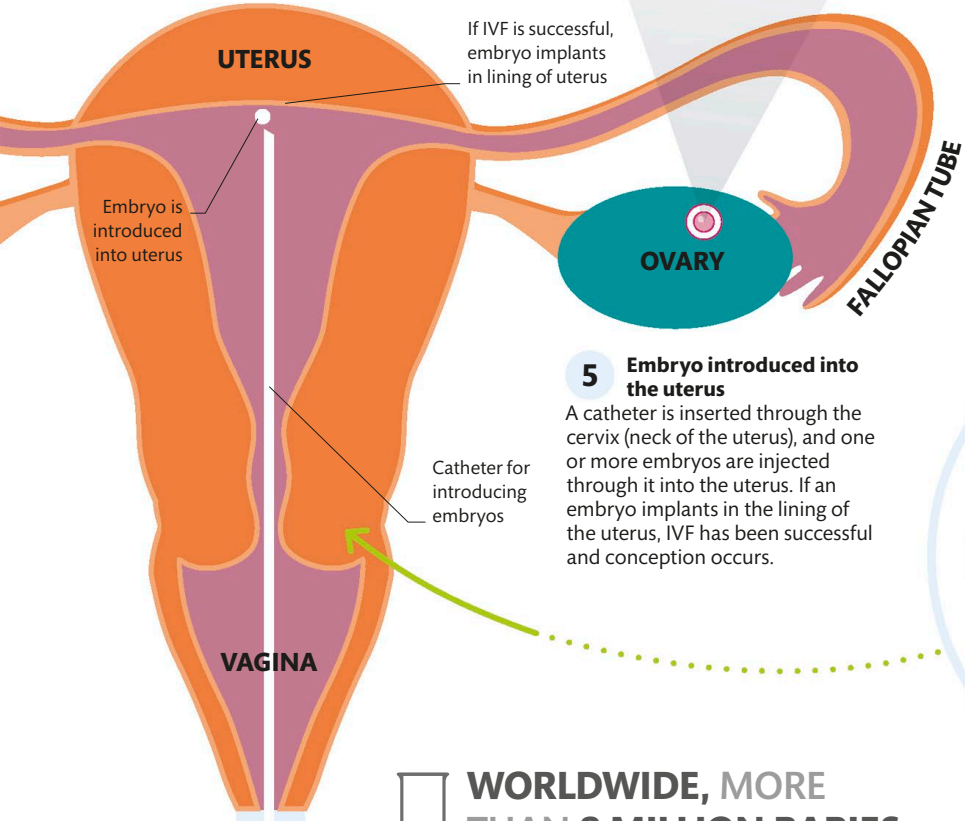
Often referred to as IVF, in vitro fertilization is any technique in which a woman's egg is fertilized outside the body. It may be performed to treat either male or female infertility. The woman is given drugs to make her ovaries produce more eggs than usual. The eggs are collected and mixed with sperm in a laboratory. If any eggs are fertilized, they are left to develop for a few days then placed in the woman's uterus. Any extra fertilized eggs may be frozen for use later.



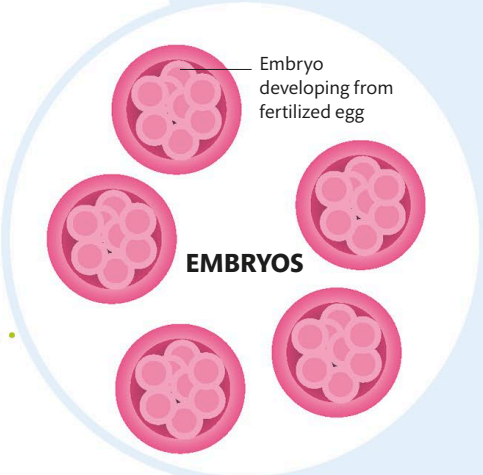
1 Hormonal stimulation
Drugs are given to stimulate the follicles in the ovaries to ripen and develop eggs. When enough eggs are ready, another injection makes the follicles release them.



2 Eggs are collected
An ultrasound probe is inserted into the vagina to identify the mature eggs, and between 8 and 15 eggs are collected with a very fine needle.



5 Embryo introduced into the uterus
A catheter is inserted through the cervix (neck of the uterus), and one or more embryos are injected through it into the uterus. If an embryo implants in the lining of the uterus, IVF has been successful and conception occurs.



4 Fertilized eggs grow
The fertilized eggs are left for three days to grow into cell clusters. To maximize the chance of successful implantation in the uterus, the clusters need to grow to around eight cells (called embryos) before they can be transferred into the woman.

WORLDWIDE, MORE THAN 8 MILLION BABIES HAVE BEEN BORN FROM IVF SINCE THE FIRST PROCEDURE IN 1978